the 969 Movement's fusion of being Buddhist and hatred of Islam.[92] Pan Zagar has explicitly called for action against hate speech, and unlike the monks of the 969 Movement, accept there is a link between speech and actions: 'Let's watch what we say so that hate between mankind does not proliferate'[93] has become one of their key slogans. This forms part of a slowly emerging counter narrative to that of the 969 Movement, for example as captured by another popular slogan: 'Don't spark hatred with your words'.[94]

Such dissent can have personal consequences, especially when the 969 Movement calls its opponents 'fake countrymen' and 'traitors on national affairs'.[95] As a result, some report feeling intimidated into keeping quiet, a worrying sign in a country sitting on the edge of genocide:

> About a year ago, a friend in my neighbourhood put stickers on his van that said: 'I will not be the cause of racial or religious conflict.' A little later, he peeled them off. 'I was worried people would be angry or violent towards me when they saw the sticker,' he said. 'The van is for business.' Who would I be to disagree? The stickers were from a campaign organized by youth groups opposing the spread of religious violence following the riots in Meiktila. My friend supports his family by driving that van.[96]

Other instances of civil groups challenging the 969 Movement include women's groups who opposed the proposed ban on inter-faith marriage as an assault on women's rights[97] in contradiction of the 969 claims that such laws were essential to protect women from Muslim violence. In this case, Suu Kyi actually did meet the activists, but those standing up to the 969 Movement continued to receive death threats.[98]

Others too are speaking out. Journalist and filmmaker Mon Mon Myat has spoken about the need to respect all Myanmar's ethnic communities in the move towards democracy.[99] Equally I met a number of journalists who work in Myanmar who told me that the government now feels that some extremist monks have gone too far[100] but, like the NLD, it may no longer be in a position to challenge them directly. As we have seen, the regime has an ambiguous view of international pressure, but would like to see the EU and UN sanctions lifted so they can continue the vital business of making money for themselves.

This does indicate that the 'vision' for Buddhism espoused by the 969 Movement and MaBaTha—the paranoid vision that if Myanmar is to have a Buddhist future, this must be grounded on the exclusion of all non-Buddhist